starting point of a very interesting line of study that could not only explain our pre-history but also provide key tools for next-generation medicine. One point, however, is clear—that Indians are a mongrel lot who come in all shapes, sizes and complexions. Genetics has merely confirmed what we can all see.

Of course, the genetic links of North Indians to some Europeans and Iranians corroborates linguistic linkages that were discerned in the nineteenth century. Most of the evidence is centred around a gene mutation called R1a1 (and more specifically a sub-group R1a1a). [27] This gene is common in North India and among East Europeans such as the Czechs, Poles and Lithuanians. There are smaller concentrations in South Siberia, Tajikistan, north-eastern Iran and in Kurdistan (that is, the mountainous areas of northern Iraq and adjoining areas). Interestingly, however, the gene is rare among Western Europeans, western Iranians and through many parts of Central Asia. In other words, we are dealing with R1a1a population concentrations that are separated by vast distances from each other. How did they get there?

A study by Peter Underhill et al published in 2010 in the *European Journal of Human Genetics* found that the oldest strain of the R1a1a branch was concentrated in the Gujarat-Sindh-Western Rajasthan area, suggesting that this was close to the origin of this genetic group. European carriers of R1a1a also carried a further mutation, M458, that is not found at all in their Asian cousins. [28] Since the M458 mutation is estimated to be at least 8000 years old, the two populations appear to have separated before or during the Great Flood. Thus, the genetic linkages between North Indians and East Europeans are best explained by the sharing of a distant common ancestor, perhaps from before the end of the last Ice Age. We do not really know why the Asian and European branches separated, although it is tempting to assume that it had something to do with climatic changes.

Note that the most common lineage in Western Europe is R1b. This is related to R1a1 and possibly also originated in the Persian Gulf area but the two lineages separated a long time ago—probably during or before the last